Between two worlds

Kodandera Subayya Thimayya was born in Mercara (Madikeri) in the present-day state of Karnataka. He was among a select number of young men chosen to train at the Prince of Wales Royal Indian Military College in Dehradun, and then at the Royal Military College at Sandhurst in England. Thimayya (and others like him) occupied a complicated place in the colonial hierarchy. As a King's Commissioned Indian Officer, he was among the first Indians to be given authority over British troops, but even though he was the equal of a British officer, he continued to experience racial prejudice in social contexts. Thimayya was also sympathetic to the aims of the nationalist leaders but, as a British army officer in charge of keeping order, he frequently found himself on the other side of them.

From 1917, ten spots were reserved for Indians at Sandhurst, the prestigious training institution for British army officers. However, very few made it through the selection process, which included tests and interviews with high-ranking army officers as well as the Viceroy.

Thimayya and several other Indian officers considered resigning from the army to join the freedom movement. However, the Congress leader Motilal Nehru dissuaded them, suggesting that well-trained officers would be essential to the defence of independent India.

A soldier and a strategist

When Britain deployed its colonial armies in World War II, Thimayya served with distinction, becoming the first Indian to command an infantry brigade on the battlefield in 1945. However, he is best remembered for his contribution during the conflict of 1947–48. He first worked with the Punjab Boundary Force, helping to deal with the horrendous violence and the huge influx of refugees during Partition. Subsequently, he was given command of